U.S. Equity Strategy & Data Science

UPDATE: 4Q25 Earnings Learnings: (Scatter)shots on goal

Despite the most EPS misses in a season since 2022, 4Q25 comped well against the year-ago quarter with +11.7% earnings growth on +7.3% sales. Tech carried the day again, especially Big Tech, and their EPS revisions are up and to the right while valuations are rolling off.

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UPDATE This publication is an update to 'U.S. Equity Strategy & Data Science: 4Q25 Earnings Learnings: (Scatter)shots on goal', originally published on 09 Mar 2026 at 04:00 EDT This version corrects for the title to Fig 5, which shows stock price reactions to misses and beats this quarter.

- **Earnings season was strong this quarter with impressive headline numbers...** EPS growth was +11.7%, and sales growth ended +7.3%. Big Tech Y/Y EPS growth remained strong at 28.4%, thanks to a late uplift from NVDA, and the rest of Tech delivered 22.3% growth (strongest in the past 3 years) and a 10.6% EPS surprise (best in the past four quarters). This helped offset below-average growth elsewhere.
- **...despite more misses than usual.** Only 74.7% of companies beat the consensus estimate, down from 83.4% last quarter and is the lowest overall breadth since 4Q22. Breadth of surprise this quarter was materially worse than the 80.6% post-Covid median but approximately in-line with the 75% long-run median (since 1998). Markets largely shrugged this off; the average 1-day excess return following an EPS miss was flattish.
- **Consensus FY26 ticked higher to $317,** thanks to TMT and Materials, though Healthcare and Energy contributed negatively to revisions. Alongside earnings guidance, hyperscalers keep raising their capex forecasts, now projected to grow 60%+ Y/Y to $715bn in 2026 before a sequential deceleration in 2027.
- **SPX NTM P/E has drifted below 21.5x,** as AI capex/financing concerns linger and geopolitical volatility weighs on market sentiment. We think revisions moving higher opens up an entry point for Big Tech. While valuations for the rest of the TMT complex look more extended, we favor the secular growth story.
- **NLP analysis of earnings transcripts suggests that AI continues to gain as a theme,** with discussion focused primarily on efficiency gains while attention to specific AI domains stayed flat. Consumer-related commentary points to easing concerns, while pricing tone still leans

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toward increases even as price-competition language picks up. Both capex intentions and credit/lending commentary have gained prominence, moving toward the upper end of recent ranges.

4Q25 Earnings Learnings

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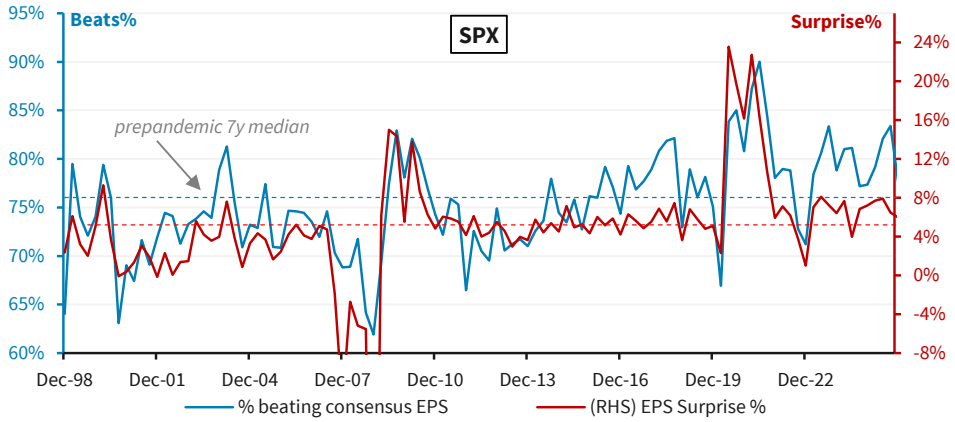
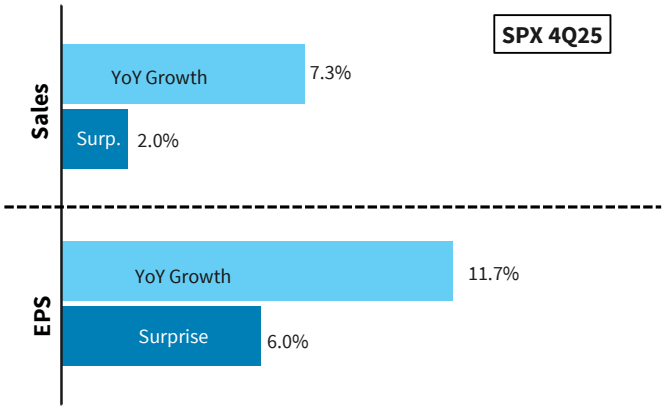
- S&P 500 revenue and EPS growth came in at 7.3% and 11.7%, respectively, both ahead of expectations (average surprise: 2% on sales, 6% on EPS) and LT medians.
- Breadth of surprise weakened meaningfully Q/Q. 74.7% of companies beat the consensus estimate, down from 83.4% last quarter and is the lowest overall breadth since 4Q22 when only 71% of companies beat the consensus estimate. Breadth of surprise this quarter was materially worse than the 80.6% post-Covid median but approximately in-line with the 75% long-run median (since 1998).
- Tech continues to post impressive beat-to-miss ratios, as did Staples and Healthcare. On the other hand, Discretionary, Materials, and Utilities missed nearly as often as beat.

FIGURE 1. Both breadth and depth of beats lagged last quarter's record high, but stayed above the pre-pandemic level



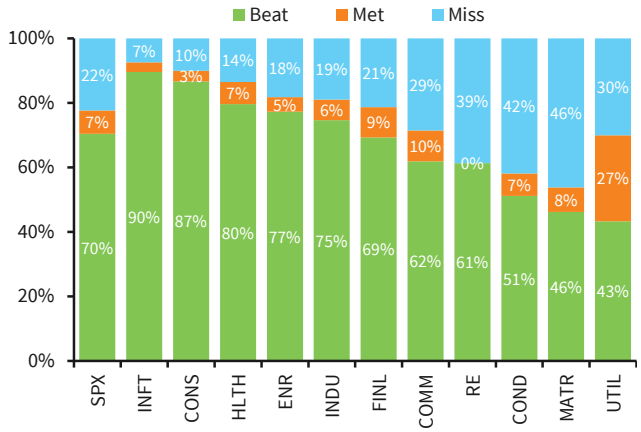
Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 2. Earnings saw surprise to the upside while sales also beat expectations



Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

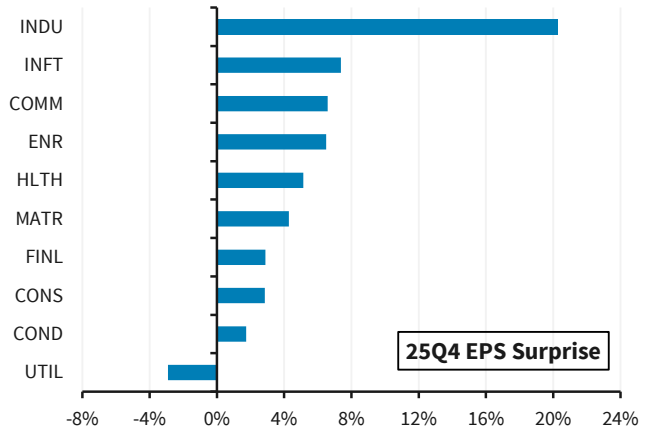
FIGURE 3. Beats-to-miss ratio was the highest for Tech and Consumer Staples, lowest for Discretionary, Materials and Utilities



Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

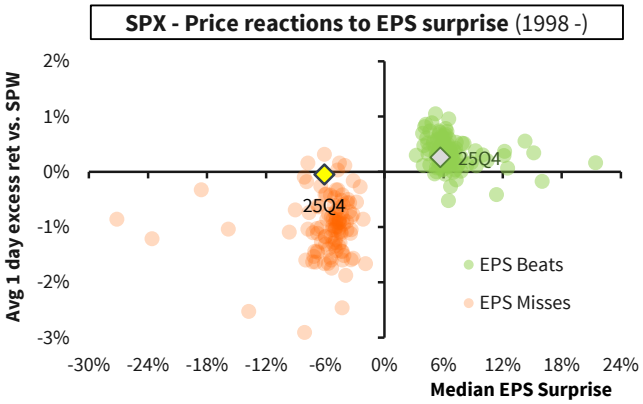
- Industrials led other sectors in EPS surprise, followed by TMT and Energy. Utilities printed an average miss, rounding out a lackluster season, while Financials, Discretionary, and Staples delivered low single digit beats.
- Markets shrugged off misses despite seeing more of them this quarter than last (and any other since 2022); the average 1-day excess return following an EPS miss was flattish.
- Big Tech's EPS surprise this quarter was the weakest of the past four quarters, though the rest of the Tech sector showed up to carry the torch for the complex. Big Tech EPS surprise shrank Q/Q across most of the 6 names except for META recovering from last quarter's one-time charge and NVDA continuing to surprise strongly to the upside.

FIGURE 4. Average surprise was the greatest for Industrials, while muted for utilities



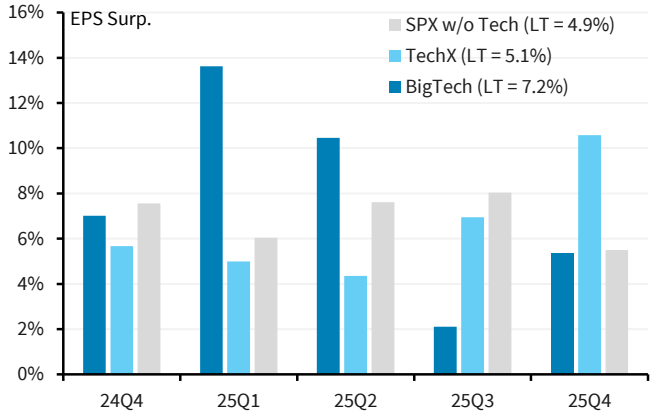
Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 5. Reactions to misses this quarter were muted, and markets slightly rewarded beats



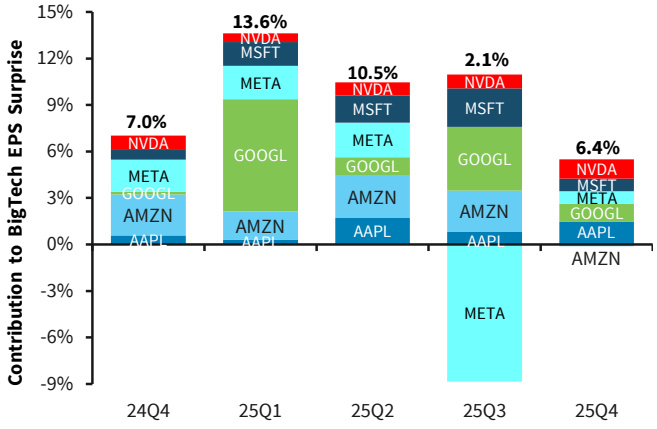
Data as of 04-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 6. TechX leads in EPS surprises while BigTech lags...



Data as of 03-Mar-2026. Techx comprises of S5INFT members without NVDA, MSFT, and AAPL.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 7. ...since BigTech EPS surprise was the weakest among the last four quarters after normalizing for META's result last quarter



Data as of 03-Mar-2026.

Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

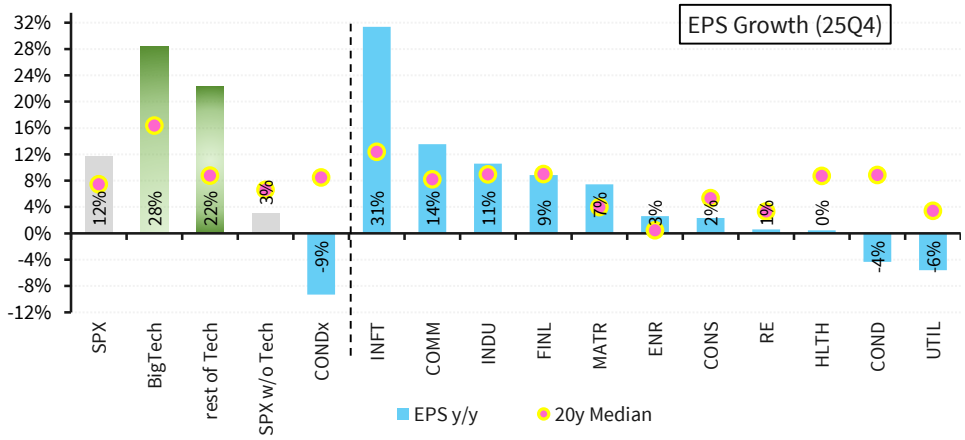
EPS growth below trend for more sectors than last quarter

- Big Tech's EPS growth remains strong at 28%, well-above the LT median but down vs. last quarter's 33%. EPS growth for the rest of Tech (22%) also came in well above LT trend levels and improved Q/Q. However, SPX ex-Tech lagged the LT median and weakened Q/Q, as the muted or negative growth in Discretionary, Energy, and Healthcare weighed on results.

- Expectations are for y/y EPS growth to accelerate for SPX ex-Big Tech, as continued beats over the past three quarters provide momentum. Expectations for Big Tech's y/y EPS growth continue to stay at elevated levels for the next two quarters, but dip in 26Q3 and recover thereafter.

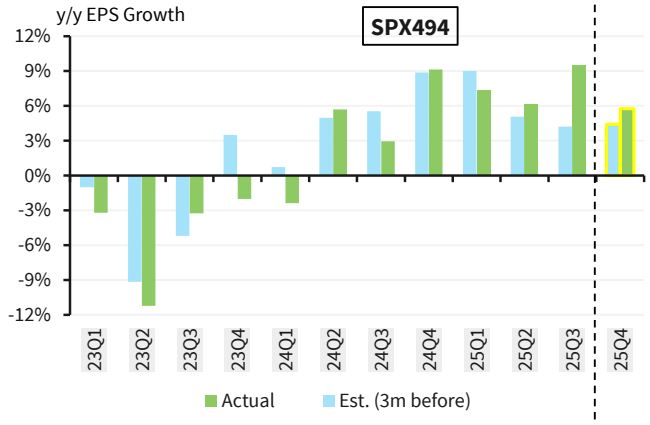
- Net profit margins improved Y/Y for TMT and Materials, but were flattish to down across the other major GICS sectors. Big Tech's net profit margin expanded to 28.4% from 26.8% in the year-ago quarter.

FIGURE 8. Tech, Industrials and Comms Svcs have seen the most impressive EPS growth, while Discretionary (ex-Amazon), Staples, Healthcare and Real Estate are areas of weakness



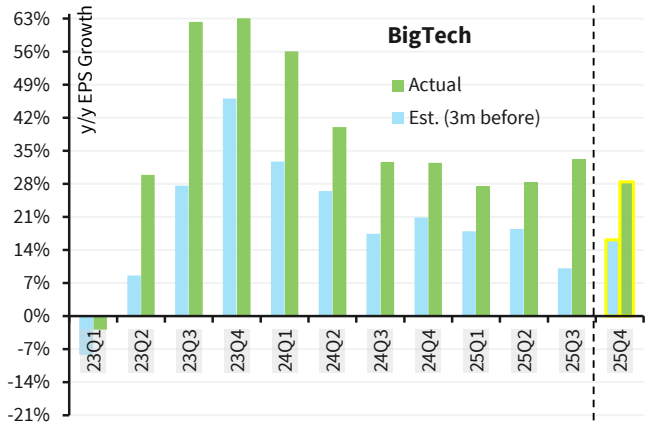
Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

FIGURE 9. SPX ex-Big Tech EPS growth continued to beat expectations, but fell short of last quarter's impressive record



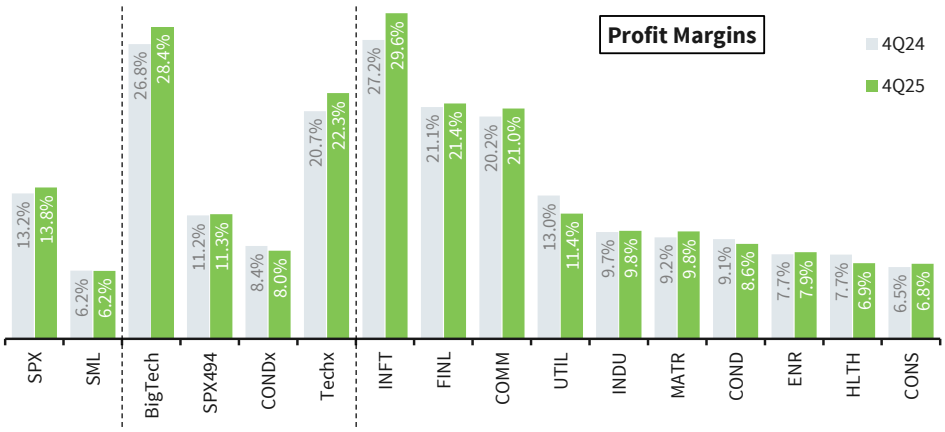
Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 10. Big Tech earnings once again exceeded consensus estimate this quarter



Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 11. Tech saw margins improve the most, while Energy, Healthcare, and Industrials saw a decline

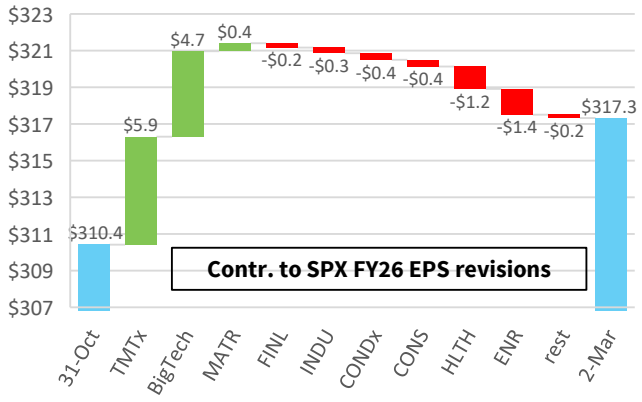


Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

Consensus FY26 EPS revised higher, as is hyperscaler capex

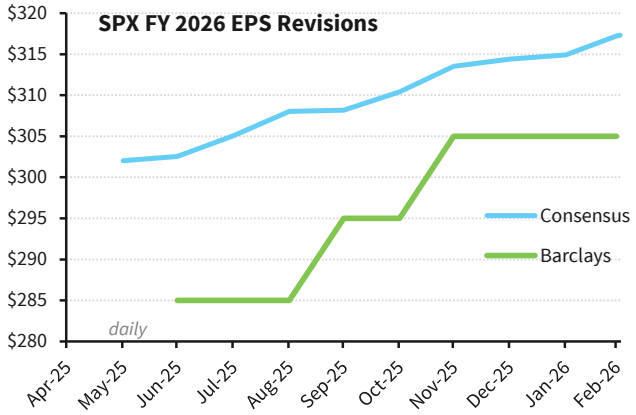
- SPX FY26 EPS estimate has been revised higher since the onset of the earnings season thanks to TMT and Materials. All the other sectors weighed on revisions, with Energy and Healthcare contributing the most negative impact.
- Meanwhile, hyperscaler capex continues to accelerate and is projected to grow 60%+ in FY26 to $715 billion, though the market expects the spending growth to slow in 2027. GOOGL and AMZN are expected to be the largest spenders, with META close behind.

FIGURE 12. TMT and Materials contributed positively to FY26 EPS revisions, while other sectors weighed on estimates



Earnings contribution is an "estimate" calculated using index shares and Qtr EPS. It assumes Index Divisor to be a constant, and so is not affected by individual stocks.
Data as of 04-Mar-2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

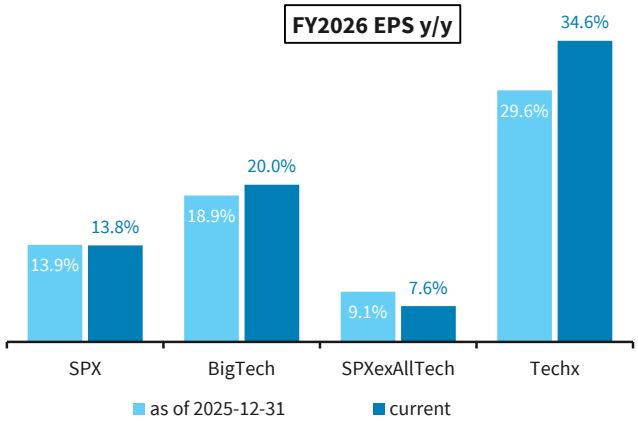
FIGURE 13. Consensus FY26 EPS has increased since the onset of earnings season



Data as of 04-Mar-2026.

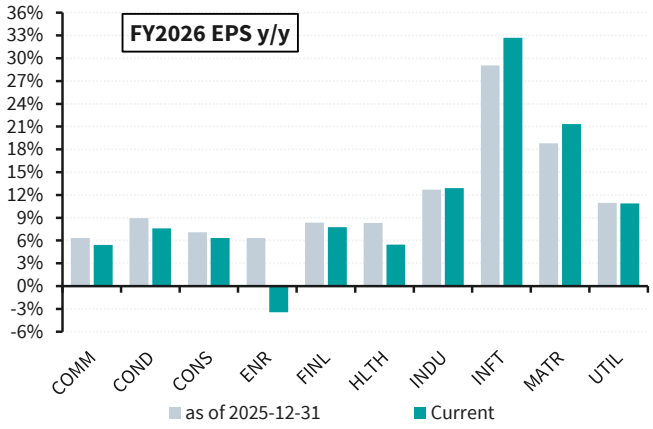
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 14. Current FY26 EPS growth estimates vs. 12/31/2025



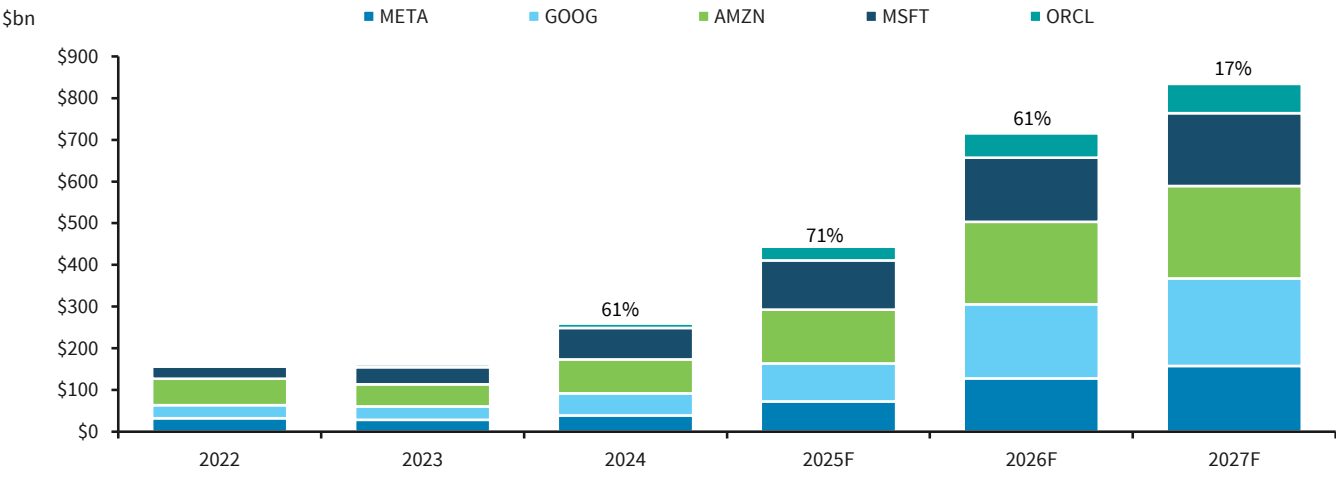
Techx comprises of S5INFT members without NVDA, MSFT, and AAPL.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 15. Current sector FY26 EPS growth estimates vs. 12/31/2025



Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 16. Hyperscaler capex is projected to exceed $715 billion in 2026



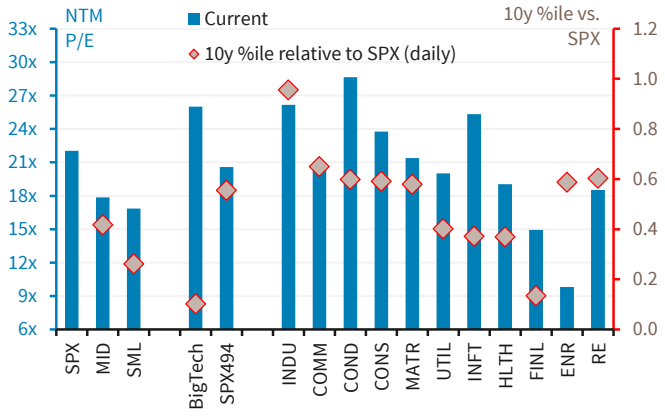
Data as of 03-Mar-2026. Amazon comprises Barclays AWS estimates/forecasts. MSFT (June 30 fiscal year) and ORCL (May 31 fiscal year) are shifted to better align with the calendar year.
Source: Company reports, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Relative P/Es most extended for Industrials, least for Big Tech and Financials

- NTM P/Es have been choppy YTD. Among sectors where we have a Positive view, Big Tech and Financials trade at attractive relative valuations (bottom quartile) to SPX. Among sectors for which we have a Negative view, we see limited fundamental support for Energy, as the sector is up 26% YTD and valuation is extended (60th percentile LT EV/EBITDA vs. SPX), though the timeline for the conflict in the Middle East remains uncertain. Valuations for Staples have also increased in the current high volatility environment.

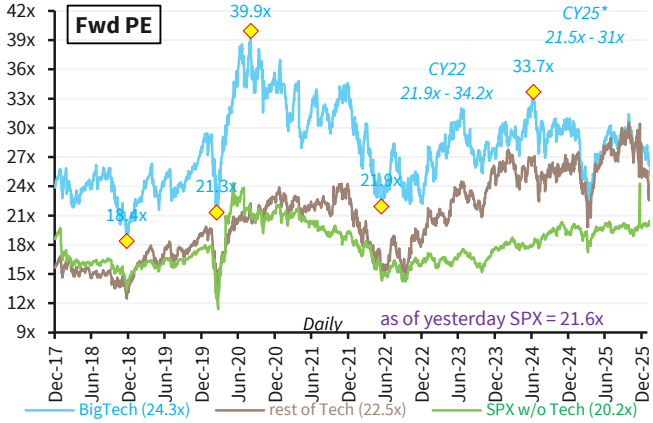
- At 24.3x NTM EPS, Big Tech multiples are at their lowest since April 2025, reflecting persistent capex and financing concerns that cropped up over the reporting season. We think this is an attractive entry point for the group.

FIGURE 17. Industrial valuations relative to SPX are the richest among sectors, and Financial relative valuations are the cheapest...



Data as of 04-Mar-2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 18. Valuations for rest of SPX hovered around after the sharp decline at the beginning of the year



Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: Bloomberg, LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

NLP analysis on earnings transcripts

Renate Marold[(v)] BCI, US

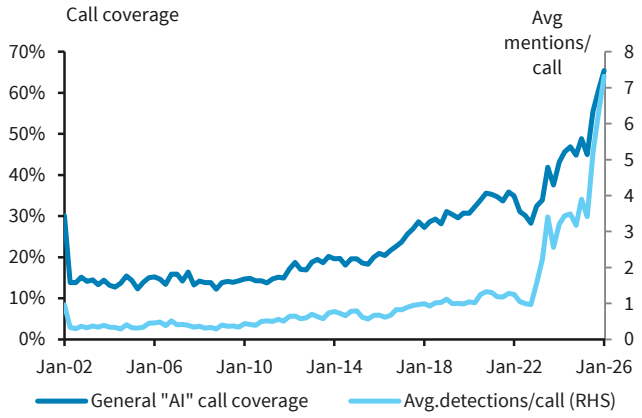
AI remains front and center in markets, also in earnings calls, with over 65% of S&P 1500 companies discussing AI, and these **discussions still focus mostly on efficiency gains**. Meanwhile, specific AI domains remain little highlighted. Among other topics we investigated with an NLP approach, we found the following:

- executives have focused less strongly on the consumer, with **reduced emphasis on consumer weakness, the low-income consumers, or choicefulness all seemingly suggesting little concern about the US consumer holding up;**
- the changing context of **pricing plan discussions could signal that executives are still more broadly planning on price increases, although intentions to compete on price might also have strengthened**;
- both CAPEX intentions and a credit/lending topic have gained prominence, now touching the upper end of (recent) ranges.

AI front and center, yet specific AI domains do not enter discussions

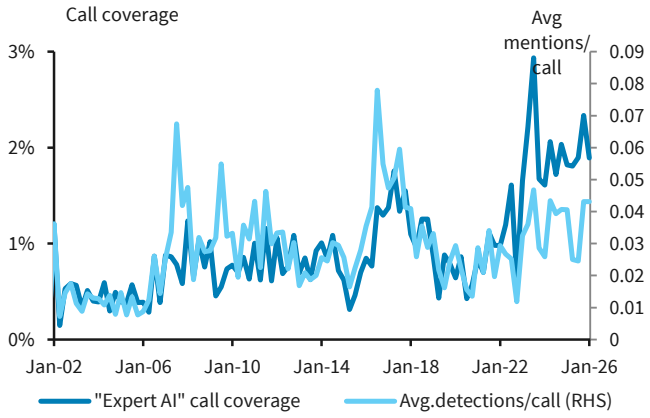
The rise of AI coverage in S&P1500 earnings calls continues. Thus far in Q1'26 reporting, "AI"-call coverage topped 65%, covering executives discussing things like AI, big data, large language models, machine learning, and natural language processing (Figure 19), which are being discussed on average ~7x per call. Mentions of specific AI domains, such as deep learning, prompt engineering, or transformer models have not shown a similar uptrend, and instead have been stagnant around just 2% (Figure 20).

FIGURE 19. Further ramp-up in mentions of general AI in Q4'25 earnings season



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

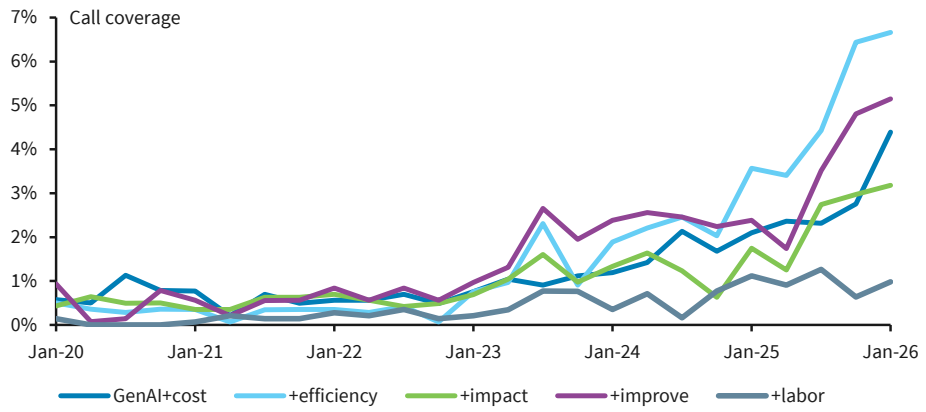
FIGURE 20. Talk about specific AI developments remain below 3Q23 peak



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

The context in which general AI is described has tended steadily toward improvements and efficiency over the last year, with references to AI topics alongside "efficiency" and "efficient" occurring in the same sentence in nearly 7% of earnings calls (Figure 21). In the current reporting season, the general AI topics were also mentioned more frequently alongside "impact" and "improve." Usage of "costs" in the discussion of AI rose sharply. While many of these discussions seem to be related to AI driving costs higher, there are also plentiful references to AI bringing cost efficiencies.

FIGURE 21. Discussions of AI (and e.g., LLMs) alongside "costs" have picked up strongly thus far in the reporting season, while AI efficiency mentions remain most common



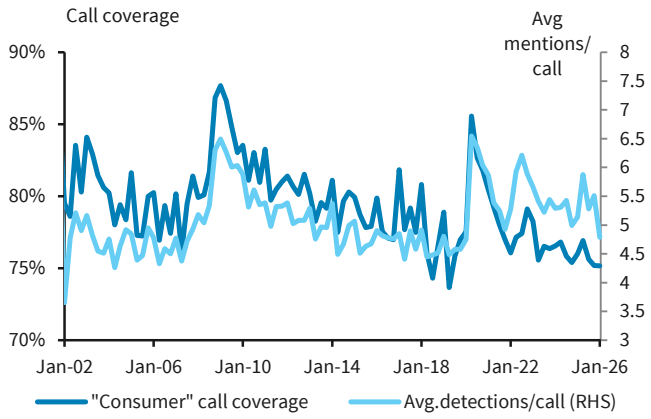
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

Discussions of the (choiceful) consumer take a backseat

In our view, various earnings call trends around the consumer and weakness point to little concern among executives about the state of the US consumer, including about consumers on the lower end.

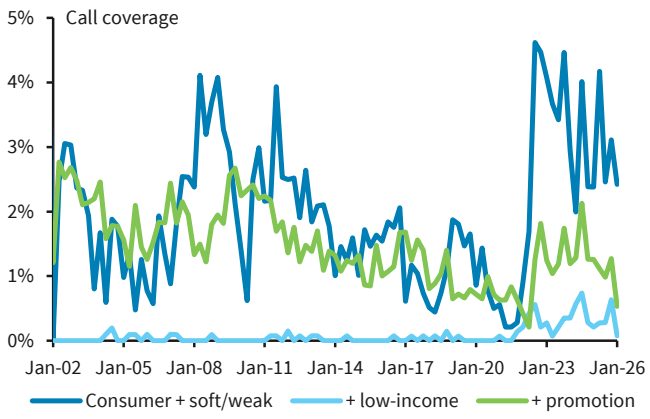
The number of companies discussing the consumer and consumption has broadly fallen since the call coverage peak at 86% in Q2'20, although it has remained a relatively important topic covered in about 75% of calls in the current quarter (Figure 22). Yet, mentions of the consumer in the context of softness or weakness sit at the lower end of recent ranges, and mentions of the low-income consumer or promotions have fallen notably from the previous season (Figure 23).

FIGURE 22. Discussions of the consumer retreat further...



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 23. ...alongside those of a weak and low-income consumer

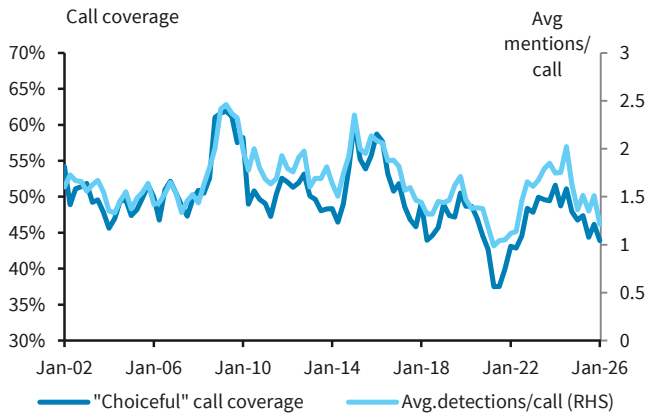


Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

To capture how strongly corporate executives focus on customers' value-seeking behavior, we look for keyword mentions in earnings call transcripts of either "choiceful," "trading down" of "promotion," or a combination of "price," "value" or "pricing," alongside one of "conscious" or "seeking." The percentage of executives referencing this type of costumer value-seeking behavior is displayed in Figure 24, showing reduced focus on the topic in the current reporting season relative to the prior. At about 44% call coverage, the share of companies talking about this behavior is notably below the ~60% call coverage peaks during the Great Financial Crisis

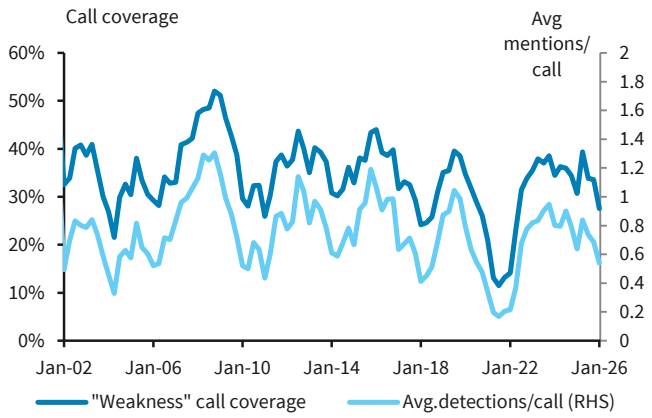
(GFC) or the more recent local peak in the Q3'24 earnings season peak. Similarly, broad softness or weakness also seemed less top-of-mind among executives, based on falling mentions in the current reporting season (Figure 25).

FIGURE 24. Descriptions of consumers' value-seeking behavior retreated further this quarter...



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 25. ...as did references to forms of weakness



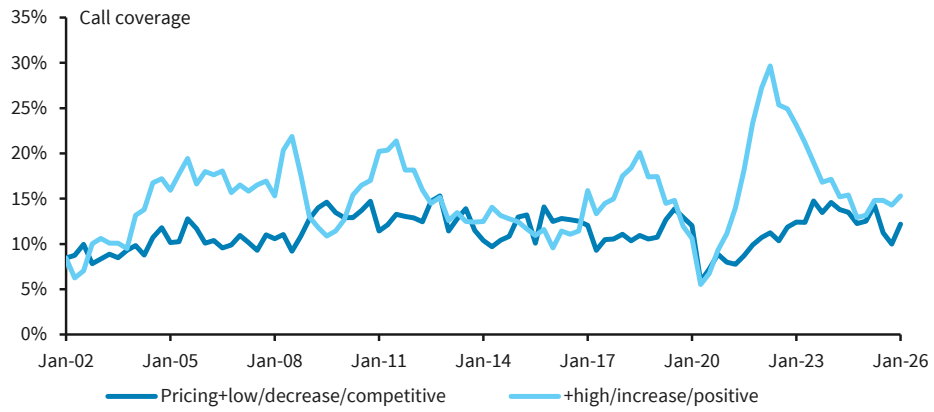
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

Jargon of upward pricing still exceeds competitive pricing language

Looking specifically at language indicative of pricing plans, we found that the share of executives talking about "pricing" or "pushing through" of prices remained at ~75% of all earnings calls - not displayed, but only somewhat elevated from a pre-COVID perspective. More interesting is looking beyond the frequency with which pricing plans have been discussed; we also examine the evolving context of such pricing discussions, which allows us to identify whether corporate executives have talked about pricing plans in a way that differs from past discussions.

Figure 26 shows that, relative to the previous earnings season, corporate executives have been describing pricing somewhat more frequently in the context of "high," "strong," "increase," "incremental," "up" or "positive" (light blue line). However, the pickup in the frequency of the context of "low" or competitive" picked up more (dark-blue line). In our view, this could signal that executives are still more broadly planning on price increases, while intentions to compete on price have also strengthened.

FIGURE 26. Evolving context used around "pricing": Language used to describe pricing suggests the focus on lower pricing picked up, yet is still surpassed by mentions of higher or increased pricing



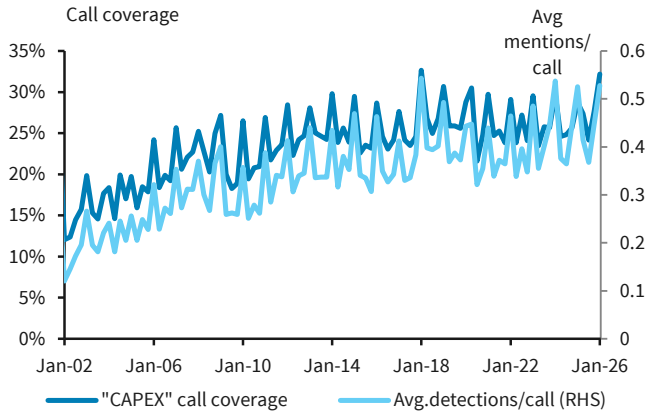
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

Slight shift in onus toward CAPEX and credit

Executives' discussions of expected capital expenditures have followed an upward trend - albeit one with quarterly volatility, bringing call coverage of CAPEX plans to the upper end of historical ranges, discussed in nearly a third of earnings calls. We capture this topic as keyword matches on "capex," "capital expenditure" or "investments," alongside outlook-related terms such as "estimates" and "intentions" (Figure 27).

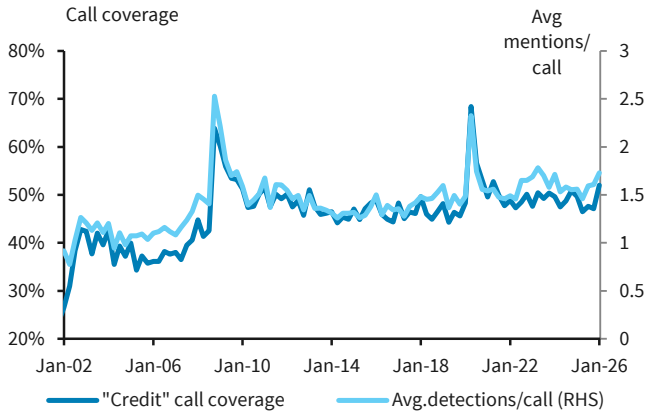
The evolution of a generic credit topic in Figure 28, capturing mentions like "lending," "funding," and "refinancing" picked up slightly from the previous reporting season, yet is now also at the upper end of historical ranges, excluding peak attention around the GFC and COVID19 period.

FIGURE 27. Call coverage of CAPEX is on the high end of historical ranges



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

FIGURE 28. Similarly, credit topic discussions are on upper end of recent ranges



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Barclays Research

Appendix A: Earnings Scorecard

FIGURE 29. **2025 Q4 Earnings Scorecard**

			4Q25 Sales		4Q25 EPS		4Q25
Sector, IndustryGrp	%Reported	%Beats	Surprise	Y/Y Growth	Surprise	Y/Y Growth	Net Margins
Comm Services	**91%**	**71%**	**1.8%**	**9.6%**	**6.6%**	**13.6%**	**21.0%**
Media & Entertainment	90%	72%	1.9%	-0.1%	6.8%	13.4%	25.6%
Telecom	100%	67%	1.2%	20.1%	5.4%	3.1%	10.9%
Discretionary	**90%**	**58%**	**1.2%**	**0.5%**	**1.7%**	**-4.3%**	**8.6%**
Auto & Components	100%	75%	0.2%	-8.6%	4.6%	-27.8%	4.1%
Consumer Srvc	100%	56%	1.9%	3.3%	1.4%	6.4%	13.4%
Durables & Apparel	91%	80%	4.4%	1.2%	12.1%	-17.4%	10.9%
Retailing	73%	36%	1.0%	4.6%	-0.1%	1.4%	8.9%
Energy	**100%**	**82%**	**3.3%**	**0.1%**	**6.5%**	**2.6%**	**7.9%**
Financials	**99%**	**72%**	**2.3%**	**7.3%**	**2.9%**	**8.9%**	**21.4%**
Banks	100%	77%	0.7%	10.1%	-0.8%	13.0%	25.8%
Financial Services	100%	68%	5.5%	6.1%	1.4%	-0.1%	22.0%
Insurance	96%	77%	-1.7%	11.1%	12.6%	33.0%	16.1%
Healthcare	**98%**	**83%**	**1.8%**	**12.0%**	**5.1%**	**0.4%**	**6.9%**
Health Eqp & Srvc	97%	79%	1.6%	14.6%	2.2%	-15.1%	2.9%
Pharma & Biotech	100%	88%	2.8%	7.6%	6.8%	11.3%	25.6%
Industrials	**99%**	**77%**	**2.3%**	**9.2%**	**20.2%**	**10.6%**	**9.8%**
Capital Goods	100%	77%	3.3%	12.2%	34.0%	19.2%	10.0%
Commercial & Prof. Srvc	93%	79%	-0.5%	5.9%	2.5%	7.9%	15.6%
Transportation	100%	77%	0.7%	4.4%	-9.1%	-7.4%	7.8%
Materials	**100%**	**54%**	**0.8%**	**1.5%**	**4.3%**	**7.5%**	**9.8%**
Staples	**83%**	**87%**	**0.2%**	**-1.6%**	**2.8%**	**2.3%**	**6.8%**
Food & Beverage	91%	85%	0.1%	3.9%	2.6%	0.3%	10.9%
Food & Staples Retailing	43%	100%	0.1%	-4.7%	3.0%	3.8%	3.1%
Household Prod	100%	86%	0.4%	2.1%	3.2%	5.1%	16.3%
Tech	**96%**	**93%**	**3.1%**	**20.7%**	**7.4%**	**31.4%**	**29.6%**
Semiconductors	95%	83%	2.9%	32.5%	7.3%	52.7%	41.6%
Software & Services	97%	93%	1.2%	10.9%	7.9%	22.3%	30.9%
Tech Hardware & Eqp	95%	100%	4.6%	23.2%	7.0%	21.5%	21.4%
Utilities	**97%**	**60%**	**6.9%**	**8.2%**	**-2.9%**	**-5.6%**	**11.4%**
S&P 500	**96%**	**75%**	**2.0%**	**7.3%**	**5.9%**	**11.7%**	**13.8%**

Data as of 03-Mar-2026.
Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

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